⭐ Causal Map and Qualia, a partner brief

An analytical back-end for values-driven organisational work.

A short brief on an idea we are exploring: partnering with a consultancy in the HR or organisational development space. We are sharing it with people who know that world, for candid reactions. Causal Map Ltd, Bath, UK. July 2026.

Where we are

Causal Map Ltd builds two tools for understanding organisations based on what their people actually say. We believe that employee narratives and stories, whether gathered purposefully via targeted interviews or otherwise, are a great insight into hearts and minds, conscious and subconscious, across an organisation.

Qualia is an AI interviewer. It holds a real conversation with each employee or stakeholder, at scale, and gathers their accounts in their own words. Each person follows a link and chats with Qualia in the browser at a time that suits them. Qualia usually asks a few open questions and then probes, following up on whatever the person raises rather than working through a fixed script. Rating scales and predefined answer options are possible but not part of the main process. The output is a set of transcripts in which people explain how they see their work, their team and what causes what.

Causal Map reads those accounts and maps stories inside them by identifying the causal claims: who says what leads to what. Every link traces back to the source text, so nothing is invented and every finding can be checked. If someone says "the new rota means I hardly see my children, so I come in tired and make mistakes", Causal Map codes that as a chain: new rota → less family time → tiredness → mistakes. Coding every interview the same way gives one combined map of the organisation: which beliefs are widespread, which belong to one team only, where the management picture and the shop floor picture diverge. Click any arrow and you see the quotes behind it and who said them.

The two work on their own or together. Qualia can feed any organisational development workflows or methods you already use. Causal Map can read interviews you have gathered any way you like. Used together they form one pipeline, from conversation to evidence, and we have used them (separately and together) with real organisations, but not as HR/OD specialists.

Synthesising stories and divergences

This is closer to ethnography than to a staff survey. A survey hands people the consultant's categories and asks them to rate each one, so whatever did not make it onto the questionnaire stays invisible. We start from open conversation and let the categories emerge from what people say.

What emerges is each person's mental model of the organisation: what they believe causes what, where they see the levers and the blockages, what they think would actually change things. These models are mostly tacit. People act on them every day, but nobody has written them down, and they often differ widely between the boardroom and the corridor. Mapping them makes them visible and discussable, in the speakers' own words rather than in anyone's preconceived framework.

The piece we are missing

We are strong on elicitation and analysis. Causal mapping has a long research tradition behind it, and has often been applied in OD, and we have plenty of ideas about how to analyse mental models in general.

What we do not have is the organisational development front end, and that splits in two. First, the memorable theory: the named approach with the catchy diagram that a client can hold in their head and if necessary pitch in an elevator. Cynefin has its domains, Lencioni has his pyramid; we have a rigorous method but no story to sell it with. Second, less cynically, the craft of being useful: we do not really know how to run the workshop or open the process that turns a map into something an organisation acts on. We are back office. That is the missing link we are looking for in a partner.

What we are open to

We are open to working with a partner who brings the client relationship and a clear point of view on organisations, and who uses our tools as the analytical back end. The partner advises their clients their way and we provide a rigorous, traceable read of what people in the organisation are saying, possibly iteratively.

The kind of partner we have in mind

Ethical and values-driven. The work should serve both the people and the organisation, for example around work-life balance, culture or wellbeing, rather than purely squeezing more output from staff.

Small or boutique. Roughly the scale where a partner is looking for an edge in this space.

At ease with causation or systems. A partner may already think in terms of feedback, loops, drivers and outcomes, or may map systems. Causal mapping fits most naturally with that language.

Willing to build a method with us. The interesting prospect is co-developing an opinionated, repeatable procedure, a named approach to reading an organisation, built on our tools, rather than buying software off a shelf. The partner brings the theory and the client craft, we bring the engine.

What a first step could look like

A short conversation to see if there is a fit, then a small joint pilot on one of your live cases, so both sides can judge the value before committing to anything larger. Steve Powell, steve@causalmap.app · causalmap.app · qualiainterviews.com